

larger, unexpected numbers to push their competition onto the back foot. As an example, if you offer \$2500 bids when the auction is plodding along in \$1000 instalments, you send a strong message to the other bidders that you have the cash to spend, transferring the auction's rhythm to come under your control.

- A novice can easily misjudge timing, so the hammer might fall before you have a chance to bid. I've seen it happen – a bidder throws up their hand a microsecond after the auctioneer calls 'sold'.

The enigma

You intentionally participate in the early portion of the auction but sit out the middle and make a late dash. You play a mind game, the aim of which is to make your competition think you've run out of money, but then – boom. These bidders always wear sunglasses, projecting mystery and cool, but it's really to mask the fear in their eyes.

Pros

- You'll be an unknown quantity to your competition, who will assume you've reached your budget when you suddenly fall silent. The auctioneer will continually ask you if you want to rejoin the bidding, but hold firm – they are not asking because they think you've made a mistake and are about to get beaten, like Eddie Maguire on *Millionaire Hot Seat*, and they do not know exactly how much your opponents have to spend. Don't give away too much in your body language and expressions – a simple shake of the head (don't waft them off with a wave of your hand; they might think you're bidding) is enough.
- Participating in the early stages of the auction will build confidence for the critical finale.

Cons

- Knowing when to make your comeback is difficult. The safest evaluation is to hold off until bidding slows, and this can be surprisingly subtle. If the tempo doesn't slow – auctions can end on a crescendo, and abruptly – you'll have snoozed through the window of opportunity.